

Rajendra Joshi

Rajendra Joshi is the Founder and Managing Trustee of Saath Charitable Trust, Ahmedabad, which he co-founded in 1989. Over 37 years, Saath, meaning "together," has grown into a family of institutions with 350+ people, touching more than 1.5 million lives through community-led work on health, education, livelihoods, financial inclusion, housing and urban development.

Education

- Born, raised and schooled in Tanzania; moved to India at about 19 for post-secondary education

Career

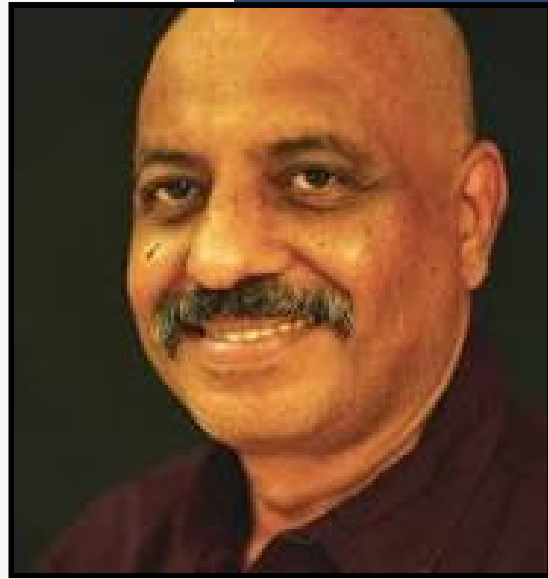
Co-founded Saath in 1989 with Pradeep Seth and Robert David, starting with health and education in Ahmedabad's low-income settlements after community consultations and surveys. Developed the Integrated Slum Development Programme and, from 1995, the pioneering Slum Networking Project with the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation: slum residents paid for their own water, roads, sanitation and electricity, beginning with a USAID-supported electrification pilot for 1,000 households.

Built Saath into a group of institutions: the Saath Savings and Credit Cooperative, Saath Livelihood Services (where he is Founder Director), the for-profit Saath Facilitators, and a multi-purpose cooperative. Its programmes include Umeed (youth skilling), Nirman (construction workers), Griha Pravesh (affordable housing), RWeaves (artisans) and Urban Resource Centres. Saath has worked across Gujarat, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

Author of *Smart Cities: Breaking the Poverty Barrier*, and of papers on integrated slum development, pro-poor accountability in water and sanitation, and recycling of construction material.

Awards and Recognition

- Schwab Foundation Social Entrepreneur of the Year (2009); Schwab Fellow of the World Economic Forum
- Ashoka Fellow (2008)
- Named among India Today's 50 "Pioneers of Change" (2008)
- Karmaveer Puraskar, iCONGO (2008), and Nagrikta Puraskar, Ahmedabad Management Association (2004)
- Finalist, Social Entrepreneur of the Year (2007), by UNDP, CII, Schwab and Khemka Foundation
- Saath has received the India NGO, HUDCO and GuideStar Platinum Transparency awards



Rajendra Joshi's Story

Raised in Tanzania and shaped by the humanist visions of Julius Nyerere and Nelson Mandela, Rajendra came to India at 19 and was struck by the inequality between castes and communities. Inspired by his mentor, the Spanish priest Father Ramiro Erviti, he started Saath after his mentor's death with two friends and barely any funds.

Leadership at Saath

Rajendra's central conviction is that communities should be seen as participants and market actors, not beneficiaries. Saath's model brings slum residents, municipal corporations, corporates and civil society into three-way partnerships. Over time it has shifted from providing services to building institutional and market capabilities among artisans, informal workers and nano-entrepreneurs.

He sees participatory leadership as involving people in both decision-making and implementation, built on trust and community ownership. Using peer-to-peer models, Saath has also worked on peace-building in some of Ahmedabad's most sensitive neighbourhoods.

He committed Saath to being a public institution rather than a personal one, with attention to governance, talent development and partnerships across three decades of institution-building.

Beyond programmes, Saath has shaped policy, researching with community organisations for the draft Gujarat State Urban Slum Policy and working with academics and planners on land tenure.

His advice to young people: the social sector offers learning far wider than a single career, and a chance to create visible, sustainable change.